

Chapter 51-3

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After Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu returned home, the torrential rain had already begun.

There were umbrellas in the car, so neither of them got wet.

By the time they got back, it was nearly dawn. Liang Shi reported her safety to Liang Xinzhou and then returned to her room.

Xu Qingzhu did the same.

The rain was too heavy, and the wind made the windows rattle loudly, with occasional thunder.

Once Liang Shi lay down, her mind was like a revolving lantern, thinking about everything that had happened tonight. She couldn't help but wonder about the situation at the old residence and what Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe would do.

She suffered from insomnia until the latter half of the night, when she got up and took a melatonin tablet.

Only then did she gradually fall asleep.

But Liang Shi had another dream.

Matching this boundless rainy night, it was like falling into endless darkness.

In the dream, she was still in the previous room—dark, enclosed, suffocating.

The ceiling, which looked extremely like a coffin lid, emitted a ghostly red glow. Directly facing the bed in the room was a bronze statue covered with black cloth. White bed sheets were scattered with white paper scraps, as if all the paper from a shredder had been dumped out.

The phone on the bedside table kept lighting up.

Liang Shi stood in this room as an ethereal light and shadow, watching the messages that kept popping up on the constantly brightening screen.

【Cheng Ran: Why are you home again? So annoying, come out and play.】

【Cheng Ran: Damn! Not replying to messages again, I'll break your damn legs next time I see you.】

【Mom: Ah Shi, you absolutely must not lift that black cloth.】

【Mom: That's a deity Mom specially requested for you. Just one week, and it's guaranteed to remove the evil spirits from your body.】

【Mom: Don't tell your brothers either. I'm afraid if they find out, they'll want to drive you away, and Mom won't be able to protect you.】

【Mom: Listen to Mom, absolutely do not lift that black cloth.】

【Mom: What would you like to eat tomorrow morning? Mom will have the servants make it. How about your favorite steamed dumplings?】

After a while, the phone screen finally dimmed.

Liang Shi turned around and saw herself.

To be precise, it was the original host, wearing a blue shirt and black long pants. Her hair was far shorter than now, just past her shoulders. She stood bewildered in the room. After a while, she picked up her phone to check the messages, first sneering coldly, then starting to cry. Low sobbing sounds filled the room.

Soon after, the original host put down her phone. She walked straight through Liang Shi's ethereal shadow and approached the bronze statue covered with black cloth.

Liang Shi really wanted to tell her: "Don't lift it."

Given Qiu Zimin's repeated warnings, she obviously wanted her to lift it.

That thing must be something extremely frightening.

Clearly, the original host also had some apprehension. Her hand fell on the black cloth, hesitating and stepping back several times.

But in the end, she couldn't resist her curiosity.

Her slender fingers lifted the black cloth, revealing the true face of the bronze statue.

Even though she was just a light and shadow, Liang Shi still stepped back half a step in horror.

The face on the bronze statue was her own—and the original host's.

There was no helping it, since they looked identical.

But this wasn't important. What mattered was that this face was imprinted on the bronze statue, with a sinister smile hanging at the corners of its mouth.

The bronze statue's hands held a blade, with the right hand's knife cutting into the left arm's position. This bronze statue had lost its left arm.

As if it had been chopped off by its own right hand.

This seemed like a form of psychological suggestion.

And this bronze statue was kneeling.

It wasn't the deity that Qiu Zimin had claimed at all.

The original host had better psychological endurance than Liang Shi. After seeing this bronze statue, she only laughed lowly, then took a very sharp object from the cabinet—a sharp dagger.

The dagger struck the bronze statue, which swayed like a tumbler toy before finally returning to its original position.

The original host hacked at it like a madwoman until she was exhausted.

Finally, she sat on the ground in exhaustion.

The dagger fell to the ground with a clang.

Watching such an original host, Liang Shi suddenly felt a pang in her heart, an indescribable sadness.

It was like the sorrow of a rabbit at the death of a fox¹.

What Liang Shi hadn't expected was that soon after, the original host picked up that dagger and cut toward her own arm.

Slashing through the blue shirt.

Blood spread everywhere.

Liang Shi desperately wanted to stop this behavior, wanted to snatch the dagger from her hands, but she couldn't do anything.

Here, she was just an ethereal shadow.

The original host's shirt gradually became unrecognizable from its original color. With the final cut, she slashed horizontally at the position parallel to the shirt buttons, and that blue button fell off accordingly.

Stained with blood.

In this extremely oppressive room.

Liang Shi watched the original host harm herself again and again, her eyes becoming increasingly gloomy.

She gradually lost her rationality, yet struggled and wandered on the edge of madness time and again.

She was like a madwoman, yet not completely mad.

Finally, she lay on the ground, looking up at the ceiling and laughing.

Heavy rain poured down, and thunder rumbled.

Her body seemed to fall into an abyss, sinking continuously downward, into the depths of cold darkness that had no bottom.

Footnotes:

¹ The sorrow of a rabbit at the death of a fox (兔死狐悲): A Chinese idiom meaning to feel sad for someone in a similar situation, often used when people of the same kind sympathize with each other's misfortune.